

Managing creative projects: An empirical synthesis of activities

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Abstract

This paper proposes a radical empirical look on the concrete activities of project managers involved in creative projects, with a specific focus on “non-administrative” issues. Through four case studies in the video-game industry, multimedia, advertising and a circus, we propose an integrated synthesis of what creative project managers actually do. Beyond analytical, cognitive, psychological, symbolic and discursive activities, we identify four sets of activities carefully coined to acknowledge the everyday work of project manager involved in creative projects. We suggest that this project manager acts as a *sense-maker*, a *web-weaver*, a *game-master* and a *flow-balancer*. This empirical “picture” raises questions on the technical and theoretical focus of research in project management where creativity is an utmost strategic issue.

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1. The creative imperative

In the first issue of this journal, Blankevoort suggested that “tools should be developed for the management of creativity to make project management complete as a recognized profession” [1]. Researchers and practitioners as well provided numerous answers to this call, in the form of general management approaches [2,3], creativity-inducing methods [4,5] and techniques [6]. Yet, little has been said on what project managers actually do to lead creative teams.

As our business world is shifting from a knowledge-based to a conception/design-based economy [7], creative projects are becoming a strategic necessity [8]. Managers and leaders are getting more concerned about the management of creative endeavours [9]. In this regard, it has been suggested that construction and product-development projects ask for different work processes, especially from the psychosocial point of view [10]. In “Design-Oriented Organizations” [11], the mobilisation of collective knowledge

through projects is essential. In projects where ambiguity increases and goals are only broadly/partially defined, collective creativity has to be fostered, channelled and managed. Beyond the interesting practical and theoretical issues on creativity skills and methods [12–18], the managerial [19,20] or structural approaches to foster creativity in individuals and groups [21–24] and the literature on creative leadership [2,25] or best practices in the management of creativity for innovation [6,26–28], less has been empirically done to assess how project managers concretely handle individual and collective creativity in projects.

In this regard, this paper aims at introducing the activities of project managers involved in creative projects in a non-abstract, non-theoretical way, with a strong focus on describing what they actually do. After a short theoretical introduction and some brief methodological considerations, the core of the paper presents an empirical “picture” based on field data from various creative industries. It is argued that the project manager engages in sets of activities coined as *sense-maker*, *web-weaver*, *game-master* and *flow-balancer* (see Fig. 1). Those activities and categories are discussed with further reflections on the management of creativity in projects.

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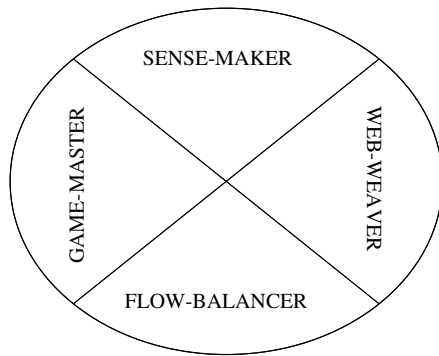


Fig. 1. The activities of the creative project manager: an overview.

2. What do creative project managers do?

As reviewed by Woodman et al. [29], creativity has been a subject of various researches with different focus mainly since the 1950s. After considering individual creativity through the life-story of creators, creativity-inducing techniques at the individual level, business creativity from the entrepreneurial point of view and as a strategic imperative, research focused on creativity as an organizational issue to be managed through specific contexts and leadership [2,25]. Organizational creativity and the management of creative teams as part of the “normal” day-to-day business activities are more recent concerns. Recent synthetic works assessed for the complexity of the phenomenon of organizational creativity and proposed to integrate its multiple dimensions through a multilevel perspective [25,29,30]. Without anticipating too much on the possibility to establish a “grand theory” of organizational creativity, this still leaves open a wide array of subjects to explore and theorize on, from the global strategic positioning of companies on the macro level, organizational structures and culture on the medium level, and to manager’s roles, interpersonal relationships and individual attributes on the micro-level. From the leadership point of view alone, researchers’ focus has been mainly on the skills, styles, and behaviours of leaders; their ability to set creative climates, to coach, to motivate and to reward their creative employees [31,32]. Interesting debates emerge and recent management and organizational theories are thoroughly mobilized to address the many issues that have arisen from the literature on creativity management. For instance, what are the effects of transactional versus transformational leadership [33] and what is the importance of emotional intelligence in leading creative people [34]. Promising perspectives occur, adopting a fresh look on traditional managerial metaphor [35] or exploring unusual subjects like the leader’s relationship to time and rhythm in creative projects [36]. Yet, due to the variety of stimulating challenges for theorization, most recent papers on the management of creativity and on leadership for creativity do not put much emphasis on the first level of understanding of any management ventures: managers’ actual practices and actions.

Acknowledging the need for micro-studies in the field of creativity management [25], this paper proposes an original empirical synthesis of the actual “activities”¹ of project managers involved in projects in creative and “techno-creative” organizations [40]. It is based on qualitative empirical inductive studies in creative industries, with a strong descriptive focus. A first ethnographic study in the field of video-games development provided the insight that the creative project manager had a strong influence on the team as a manager of context more than as an administrative manager [41]. Furthermore, it appeared that a creative project team could be described as a “playful community” with a strong work ethic organized around three main activities: never-ending learning, collective knowledge sharing and mutual challenging [42]. In this regard, the present research empirically suggests that specific “activities” are at the core of the creative project manager’s work and performance. As little empirical descriptive literature was available on the managers’ concrete activities in creative projects, case studies were conducted from 2002 to 2004 in order to explore this subject further. We will now review the research method and briefly introduce the projects considered. It will then report the main findings as four sets of detailed “activities” and finally reflect on some theoretical and practical insights.

3. Research method

This is a cases study based research which derives from an exploratory ethnographic field study on the video-game industry in the tradition of grounded theory [43,44] and qualitative research on emergent phenomena [45–47]. Set in the second most important development studio in the world,² it described and analyzed the specific management activities and work ethic in this industry. Among other conclusive insights, it appears that project managers (PMs) play a central role in the company, yet their major talents lie not in planning or controlling, rather in dealing with people in and around the project. Specific activities lie at the heart of their work, in parallel with more traditional administrative activities. Drawing on this insight, further research was implemented in creativity-focused industries in Montreal, Canada: multimedia software for the TV industry, general advertising, and a circus company (field observation and semi-structured interviews with project managers and team-members) (see Table 1). Departing from most recent experimental settings for creativity research (see for instance: [48,49]), we chose a “real-world/

¹ We voluntarily use this neutral word, “activity”, to depart from usual categories like roles, skills, behaviours, attributes and the like. It aims at focusing on the concrete actions of managers as they have been observed through fieldwork. We partly follow Mintzberg’s work on “roles” [37] and “mindsets” [38], yet we prefer to refer here to the PMs’ work inductively as “practices”, in the legacy of Schön’s “reflective practitioner” [39] or again, simply “activities”.

² Fourteen months of field presence, observations, conversations and questioning validated by in depth interviews.

Table 1
Description of the projects

Projects	Duration (months)	People	Research data			
			Field presence (weeks)	Interviews	Format of research product	Pages
<i>Video-game</i> : a core-team of five lead game-designers and a script-writer progressively aggregate with modular teams of software developers, graphic artists, sound engineers and testers, up to 80. The game started with a new concept. Except for the core software, everything had to be created and developed from scratch: interactive storyline, characters, settings, maps, and game-play						
80% Creation	22	Up to 80	60	>20	Monograph	230
<i>Real-time animation TV software</i> : 12 programmers working on a piece of software used to add on-screen comments and stats to live reports (sport events, political elections. . .). Adaptation of a previous version with new real-time rendering capabilities						
Adaptation: 50% creation	5	Up to 12	3	5	Case study	46
<i>Advertising campaigns</i> : based on a requirement from a customer, a very autonomous small creative team would define a product placement, chose a media format (TV, radio, magazines, boards. . .) and create an ad with punch line and graphics. As product placement and media choice were almost standardized, the main part of the project remained the creation of an original concept with a powerful and well-targeted message						
Pure creations	>1	Up to 5	1	5	Case study	24
<i>New circus show</i> : seven artists decided to create a new show independently from institutionalized circus. Their self-imposed challenge was to craft a consistent show from scratch with a background story on everyday life						
Work in progress: 100% creation	18	9	2	5	Case study	22

real-life” field approach to let project managers express their practices in their own words. Interviewees were encouraged to “tell the story of the project” in a subjective/reflexive mode, with a strong emphasis on description. Based on verbatim and field notes, the different stories were compiled together as case studies. Those stories were then read in parallel by two readers, with a focus on PMs’ non-administrative activities. After comparison and discussion, four main categories of “activities” have been identified with support from specific meaningful field quotes. Based on management literature, the next step consisted in carefully coining those activities and sub-activities. Faithful to the interpretive ethnographic tradition, we present the reader with precise meaning-rich labelling to faithfully and consistently account for our observations.

According to our observations, every project manager was fully aware that their goal was, as mentioned by one, to “do something different, to differentiate from the competition, (. . .) to make something still unheard of”. This radical vision of creativity is still congruent with the generally accepted definition of creativity as “the creation of a valuable, useful new product, service, idea, procedure or process” [29]. The projects considered here had different goals, scopes and budgets but could all qualify as collective creative endeavours. In each case, a PM took charge of the organization and coordination of the team, with a relatively strong involvement in the creative process.

4. The “activities” of creative project managers

In the following section, we propose an integrated account of the set of specific “soft”, non-administrative activities we identify, built around four main themes, each of which is split up in sub-themes. Those sub-activities are

presented in the logical order they appear in creative PMs’ day-to-day activities. Due to the voluntarily qualitative orientation of this paper, theoretical comments and references will be considered in the final discussion (see Fig. 2).

4.1. The project manager as sense-maker

Firstly, the PM makes sense out of the collective effort. She/he builds the project team identity through the crafting of the situated collective understanding of what is at stake. In other words she/he translates the collective enactment of the project into a shared meaning that is constantly reasserted through informal communication and formal meetings [50–52]. She/he gives a convergent direction to the multiple individual talents at work in the project team. At the same time, the PM seems all the more involved in building meaning through interactions with other stakeholders in the company (corporate sponsors or partners, functional managers allocating team-members, resource-persons with technical or managerial expertise or sales representatives in the field). The PM also makes contact with external resource-persons belonging to his/her own personal network, mainly on technical and commercial issues. He/she even uses personal partner or family members as sounding boards to test ideas and insights or vent feelings about the project and its dynamics.

Practically, this consists in a set of analytical, cognitive, psychological, symbolic and discursive activities. Not always conscious but ever-present in the PM’s practice, those activities aim at bringing answers to two simple yet essential sets of questions: “*What are we together for?*” and “*How do we translate this into concrete actions?*”

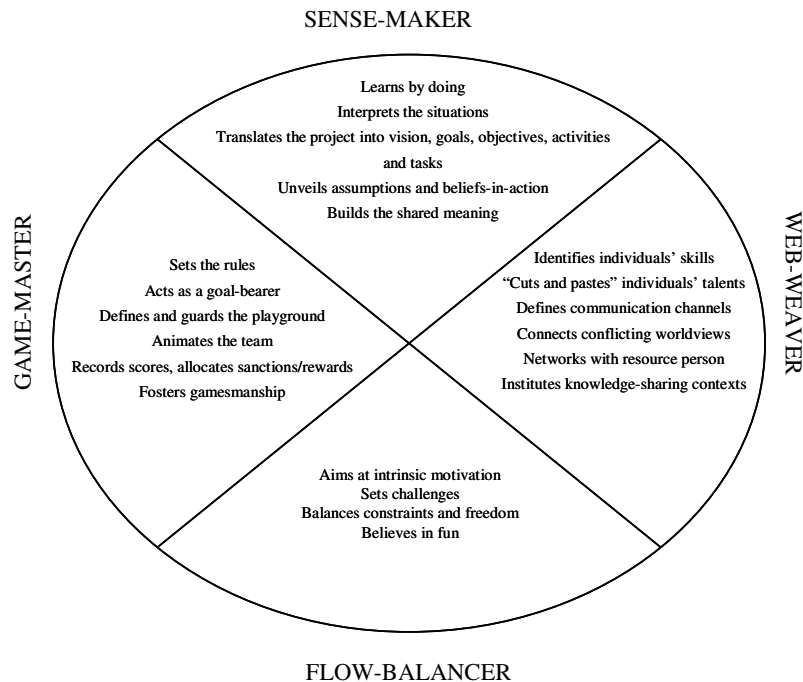


Fig. 2. The activities of the creative project manager.

- *The project manager learns by doing.* The creative PMs we observed mostly relied on an inductive discovery and understanding of the project. A common comment was: “*We learn as we go*”! One of the PMs added: “*...at the beginning, we have a broad idea of what we want and how we are going to make it, but we define and refine it in the process*”. Another one emphasizes the challenge of creation:

“This hasn’t been done before. It was new to all of us. As the leader, I had to make sense out of it. I talked and listened a lot. (...) Even if I had my own ideas, I had to confront them with others, then we tried together, we tested, we learned and we built on that”.

The “hands-on” approach seems to be essential here. This inductive learning allows the PM to get the “big picture” in order to help each team member situate his/her activities in the project.

- *The project manager interprets the situations.* In one specific case, the PM would begin every formal discussion with the team with the same introduction: “*Now, this is what’s happening...*” A detailed explanation would follow to reiterate the issues at stake into the context of the moment. He uses the same sentence when he had to change the tasks requirements of a team member, to ground this request in the broader project context. He would adopt the same explanatory attitude when a team member expressed disinterest at a certain stage in the project:

“What is happening is that you’re not excited any more because you made it! The (technical) solution you found is superb, but now you don’t feel the challenge anymore. You need to see it in another way: the challenge is in the implementation now...”

– That’s right... I feel it’s going to be an interesting challenge too to explain how it works to the guys...”

The PM does not impose his/her understanding of the situation to the team member but tries to put the micro-issue back into the broader perspective of the project. One of the PMs emphasized that he was “thinking out loud”. As he was unfolding his thought, he tried to get input and feedback from the team member. Those interpretations resulted from a co-construction of meaning with the team-members, to allow them to understand their part in the big picture.

- *The project manager translates the project into vision, goals, objectives, activities and tasks.* The point here is not only to divide the mandate into tasks and sub-tasks and then to distribute roles and responsibilities in the classic taylorian-fayolian approach. It deals with literally translating a general plan into individual mandates that should be a meaningful experience on two levels. They have to carry a significant meaning for the person involved and also make sense as a part of the whole project. In our observations, PMs would distribute challenges according to each team member talents and/or tastes. In the case of video-game development, the PM assigned the design of “camera” points of view in the game to a game-designer particularly interested in movie-making. As common sense as it may seem, it means the PM has to develop a macro/micro understanding of the project based on his/her formal and informal, more personal knowledge of the team-members.

- *The project manager unveils assumptions and beliefs-in-action.* When divergence occurs, the PM tries to unveil the source of the misunderstanding and to reframe the situation. In the case of the multimedia software company,

one of the beliefs-in-action was that the team-members had to compete against each other to showcase their skills in order to get in line for a possible promotion. The PM had to acknowledge the competitive drive of the team-members and to put it back into perspective of teamwork at the same time: “*You all want to be better than your friends, to show what you can do. It’s ok, but you are all doing a great job! So please don’t forget that you’re working together*”.

This is an ongoing part of the work that asks for constant attention from the PM. In action, he/she cognitively puts his/herself in the shoes of the employee to understand his/her point of view and to frame it back into the project alignment. It generally aims at shifting from an individual diverging understanding of the project to the common formally accepted understanding of the collective endeavour.

- *The project manager builds the shared meaning.* “*It’s a constant issue to me: as a team, we need to know where we are heading*, mentioned the PM in the multimedia software company, *that’s why I remind them often what this project is all about*”. Our observations suggest that an important part of the PM’s activities aims at building the “shared meaning” [51], not only through systematic reassertions in formal meetings, but also through the every day interpersonal micro-activities mentioned earlier. As one video-game PM puts it:

“I realised that on many occasions I was always coming back to what the project was about. (...) Once (the employees) understand the project, they know where they stand. They understand their own contribution to the project”.

In parallel with this process of establishing the shared meaning as the collective cognitive basis of the project, the PM works at building the ground for work with the internal and external stake-holders.

4.2. The project manager as web-weaver

In creative activities and projects, members act as playful “bricoleurs”,³ crafting a “mosaic”, creating their tools and products through a cut-and-paste process of various pieces of knowledge [53–57]. The PM her/himself acts as a cut-and-paste integrator of people inside and outside the team. She/he engaged her/himself in intense networking activities. She/he has to put and fit together the diversified talents, abilities and ideas of the team-members, mostly through the identification and linking of resource people and the weaving of communication channels.

- *The project manager identifies individuals’ skills, knowledge and talents.* In the cases observed here, the team is assembled on an ad-hoc basis that gives a lot of room to personal relationships and micro-politics as well as to the advice of trusted colleagues or to the recommendations

and pressure of powerful ones, followed by negotiations with the corporate sponsors and with the functional managers. A PM in the video-game studio comments: “*When I see one guy (in another project) making fast progress or popping new ideas, I try to learn more about him and I do what it takes to get him excited with my next project. I want to make sure to always get the best guys*”! Another PM in the multimedia firm explains: “*I want to know what (my employees) can do. (...) As I identify expertise, I’m able to put them to work together...*” This first step in the process of skills identification is essential to build an efficient team.

- *The project manager “cuts and pastes” individuals’ talents.* Following the identification stage, the next step consists of finding the “fit” between the team-members in terms of technical and non-technical, social skills. The PM wants to concretely induce synergy between the different team-players. In all the cases we observed, this was achieved through the physical settings of the office. As this could seem very taylorian – proximity is defined by tasks dependency – this also has a lot to do with social skills. For instance, in a bilingual team, the PM always made sure to put a perfectly bilingual employee between a French-speaking and an English-speaking employee. In another case, the PM insisted in not placing face-to-face the desks of two employees that did not get along well. The PM wants the relationships to foster learning through apprenticeship or cross-fertilization of knowledge.

- *The project manager defines communication channels.* In classical management theory, organization asks for coordination [58]. In this perspective, the PM acts as a gate-keeper. For instance, she/he asks junior employees to interact on specific issues only with a specific senior. He guides the employee towards the right people based on their technical skills and/or on organizational (in)formal habits. For instance, in the video-game company, junior game-designers were not allowed to talk directly to their counterparts in the animation studio on the same project. They had to go through a gate-keeper responsible to keep tracks of orders and to frame them into the proper vocabulary of graphic design to avoid confusing requests. It also helps to reuse parts already available, so that they would not have to “reinvent the wheel”.

- *The project manager connects conflicting worldviews through translation.* In multi-disciplinary, multi-background teams, the issue of shared meaning is far from obvious. On many occasions, we observed the PM arbitrating issues between team-members. Tensions or conflicts usually arise from misunderstandings rooted in different worldviews induced by academic and professional backgrounds. When a game-designer asks a programmer to design an animated “rope” as a decorative object in a virtual setting, he thinks it’s a very simple task and does not understand the rebuttal from the programmer, rather promoting a stick. The project manager has to find out from the programmer and explain to the designer that a rope, as simple as it seems, is a very complex physical object highly

³ The usual pun on words is even more relevant than ever here: the “bricoleur” acts as a “bris-colleur”, literally cutting and pasting skills, knowledge and talents.

demanding in computer power. To be able to settle similar conflicts, the PM has to learn the culture, *ethos* and even jargon of each profession involved in the project. This let us think that curiosity and a strong interest for discovery lies at the heart of the PM job, in parallel with strong skills in listening and learning.

- *The project manager networks with the “resource-person”*.⁴ The PM acts as resource-person especially in terms of knowledge identification, developing relationships inside the project and the company and also outside the borders of the company. In many cases, the PM in the video-game firm reacted to questions with the same sentence: “Did you go see X or Y? Did you talk to W or Z”? X, Y, W and Z were previously identified as skilled people regarding the issues at stake. In the multimedia firm, the PM used to spend a lot of his personal free time socializing with people in the TV industry or with friends with specific computer skills. Back at work, he could settle issues by referring team-members to external resource-persons. This intense social activity in mastering the social-political environment of the project seems to provide strategic advantages in problem-solving.

- *The project manager institutes knowledge-sharing contexts*. In the four cases, almost every meeting we attended started with a reminder of what the project was about and its strategic relevance. Following a formal introduction, the PM would act as animator and moderator, channelling discussions at the beginning, stimulating questions/reactions, even stirring up debates, then setting collective and individual agendas as a conclusion. In addition, in the video-game studio, when one of the employees found a clever technical trick or a nice piece of artwork, it was normal practice for the PM to stop every activity and to ask the person to showcase this contribution. In four contexts, curiosity for others’ work and a questioning attitude would be considered a normal, expected attitude. Employees searching for isolation were informally but firmly invited to participate in social events with team-mates at work and after work; otherwise they would be progressively informally ostracized. Again, this sharing attitude is enticed by the physical setting: open spaces, desks organized in circles. . . In the performing art case, most members of the project even shared a multiplex house.

Once the environment of the project is firmly established through the collectively shared vision; communication and knowledge-sharing attitudes seem to flow freely. Then the PM engages in another type of activity. This could be generically sum-up as “coaching”, but we prefer to present it as a twofold reality, the first focused on the animation of the team efforts – the “game-master” –, the second with a strong emphasis on individuals’ motivation – the “flow-balancer”.

4.3. The project manager as game-master

Management of creativity at work is merely seen as the art of setting the material, social and symbolic limits of the workspace collectively experienced as a creative playground [2,14,15]. As the game-master, the PM sets the goal, negotiates the rules and provides the materials/resources for the game. As a leader, she/he encourages the interdisciplinary players/team-members to “co-opetively” build on each other’s contributions. It is suggested that in such an environment, the art of being an efficient PM merely consists of crafting a “good enough environment” [59] where the team can play the creativity game.

- *The project manager sets the rules*. In any organizational setting, the first responsibility of the “boss” is to set the agenda. This would also apply in creative projects. The PM is expected to set the rules. This activity is twofold. First, the PM reasserts the goal of the collective effort. He/she explains what is inside the scope of the team effort and what is not. For instance, in the video-game studio, the marketing and sales sides of the project are outside the scope. The PM states the famous iron-triangle: specifications, resources and timetable for the project: “We are going to make this great game. It has to be beautiful, original and fun. You have what it takes to make a great game. But remember this has to be over in July”.

Setting the rules also deals with every day activity. The game designers were allowed to play video-games to keep in touch with the industry and to find inspiration or comparison in other products. The PM had to set a strict set of rules: playing was agreed upon during lunch breaks or after work and only on necessary occasions during working hours.

- *The project manager acts as a goal bearer*. Once the goal is known, accepted and shared, the team needs an impulse. It is often a simple sentence that is heard at the end of the kick-off meeting to inspire the team-members. Often, it comes back again and again, almost as a slogan⁵ used in times of low motivation or even in times of crisis. It’s a reminder of what lies at the heart of the project and of the team involvement. In the video-game firm, the PM used to conclude with: “Let’s go guys! Let’s do it! It’s going to be the best game in the world ever!” In the multimedia firm, the PM closed the meetings with: “Let’s hit the screens. The whole world is going to see us!” In the performing art group, the informal leader would cheer up the team with the sentence: “Let’s show the world who we are!” That would sum-up the spirit and goal of the project: expressing each artist’s creativity and building on each others work to show on stage how extraordinary talents they developed. In the scientific tool company, working to develop systems for crime labs, the tone was softer but still very determined. “We are going to save lives”. This symbolic reassertion of the goal of the project seems important for the teams to

⁴ This expression is widely used in North America and especially Canada where it describes a person who could act as an expert or a useful help and reference on a specific subject.

⁵ Keeping in mind that for the Scots the word “slogan” means an war-cry, to launch a battle. . .

go back to every day tasks with renewed energy and inspiration.

- *The project manager defines and guards the borders of the playground.* The PM is responsible for the convergence of individual efforts, but should not completely define their tasks if she/he still wants to leave some space for creative development through divergence. The project can thus be described as a playground, with clear borders surrounding a free space. The team-members can play freely in this space, enjoying healthy and creative divergences, but as soon as one is too close to the limits, divergence threatens to be too strong to fit into the collective work again. The PM has to blow the whistle each time he/she thinks one team member is wandering too far from the focus of the project. The PM in the multimedia firm explains: *“One of the guys seemed to be on his own. He wasn’t part of the team in his behaviour. I had to talk to him. He wasn’t doing a bad job, but still... he wasn’t aligned with the other’s efforts”*.

- *The project manager animates the team.* The PM also plays the positive role of a coach, concerned not only with work issues, but also within team-members as people and with the atmosphere in the project. Every morning, the PM in the video-game firm spent around two hours on administrative issues, but in mid-morning he would wander around the workspace. He would share ideas with one person or another, ask questions, listen a lot. Sitting at one desk for some time, he had some words of appreciation for the work done. Those moments seem to be really appreciated by the team-members and eventually conversations would start on various work or personal issues. In the multimedia firm, in the quietest times in the day, the PM used to start some “mess”, starting a fight by throwing crumpled paper balls to one of the team-members, quickly joined by the others members. He explains:

“I don’t want them to fall asleep or to start getting bored. I know this is a serious and often stressful job. They must stay concentrated, but sometimes it’s good to unwind a bit. So I act crazy sometimes just to release some tensions and remind them that all this shouldn’t be too painful... It gives them more energy to continue on”.

This kind of behaviour acts as a ritual to keep things in a healthy perspective and to reassert the existence of the project team as a true social community underneath the formal functions and organizational pressures.

- *The project manager records scores and allocates sanctions and rewards.* This social link and trust are also based on the perceived fairness of the PM. In the video-game project, when the PM noticed a special performance from an individual, he/she would stop all activities and ask the team-members to come and enjoy the interesting piece of work and learn from it. This would start a team discussion, with technical questions and words of appreciation and the team-members would go back to work with renewed motivation. On the opposite side, when a designer would make a mistake or would not follow the rules, the PM would not put him under the spotlight. The PM would have a serious

conversation with the person on the issue, trying to put the focus on learning to prevent this from occurring again. He would later share his thought on the issue through email in a most objective way, not mentioning the person involved, to foster learning in the team. The PM used to take notes on every good and less good “moves” he was aware of as a base for future promotions and career evolution.

- *The project manager fosters gamesmanship.* The PM, like it or not, is a role-model. He/she sets the standards in the team, particularly in terms of work ethic and of the community “ethos”: the specific, idiosyncratic, emergent and relational culture of the team. When the team finds a balance between individual involvement in the tasks and collective knowledge sharing, it seems that the project flows more easily towards its goals. If the PM plays by the rules, the team-members are going to be drawn into playing by the rules. If she/he allows some space for errors/right of failure, as opportunities to learn, the team-members are going to be more prone to try new things, to take risks and to innovate.

In the multimedia firm, two similar projects with the same final client had very different trajectories due to the PM behaviour towards their team-members. The PM fostering competition in the team ended dealing with conflict and respect issues. The “friendly but fair” PM had it easier, not being too lenient but establishing a healthy co-competition.

The PM exerts a strong influence not only on the behaviour of team members, but also on their attitudes towards the project. In the advertising agency, the PM would always stress the creative and stimulating aspect of the request from the client: *“I know this (mandate) seems really boring, but I’m sure you can surprise us. I know you’re going to come out with some incredible stuff”*. As a result, the two employees stopped complaining, went back to work and started sharing their wild ideas.

Acting as a game-master, the PM sets the playground where the team is going to play and she/he motivates the team by setting the stage for the expression of collective creativity. In the next section, we address a more individual, one-on-one aspect of these motivational activities.

4.4. The project manager as flow-balancer

Finally, the PM aims at defining a specific environment that should allow each team-mate to get involved at full potential. As the project/game appears as a space of constructed and constrained virtual freedom to be actualised through play [60–66], the project manager adjusts the experience of the individual project members so that they would feel at the same time supported and challenged in the process [2].

- *The project manager aims at intrinsic motivation.* The more the PM knows the team-members, the more she/he gets to understand what motivates them and can tailor their mandates. Considering the sources of motivation of

the “Y Generation” at work [67–69], a PM in the video-game studio explains:

“Those guys are not excited about money. They don’t fit in hierarchical relationships and they don’t think in terms of career track. They want to do something interesting. They want to learn. They want stimulation through challenges, teamwork and fun. (...) (I have) to discover what arouses their brains and guts”.

In the circus case, the almost self-directed team built its creation on the respect of each individual’s desires to engage in different types of challenges. For instance, one of the artists was more involved in story-telling, so he was responsible for the scenario. The one more concerned by the pure physical aspect of the show became responsible for the fitness and contorsionism training and coaching. The administrative manager comments: *“That’s self-organization, but the rule is: if you choose to do it, it’s because you have a peculiar interest in it. If you choose it; there are more chances that you’re going to perform above the expectations...”*

Another very efficient key to intrinsic motivation seems to be translating organizational goals into challenges.

- *The project manager sets challenges.* “Y Generation” expects to be challenged at work [67–69]. The video-game PM closed each weekly meeting on a challenge for the week:

“Marketing expects us to produce a working demo to showcase the 3D settings. We are going to give them this demo and more than that: this is going to be a fully working demo, with light effects and artificial intelligence in place. I really want you to impress them, so give it your best shot”!

The PM is not only responsible for setting the goals, but also to literally frame those objectives in the way that would appeal to the team-member. The PM has to be very sensitive to every word he uses in setting the mandates. One employee would react to technical terms when an other would only respond to visionary words of inspiration. This very subtle social skill means that the PM must personally know enough about each team member to be able to grasp their tolerance or aversion to stress, to difficulties or adversity. A PM in the video-game firm explains:

“All along the project, I have to reframe the task descriptions according to the worldview and the style of the guy I’m talking to. As I’m talking, I look for the words or the ideas that would trigger a reaction, positive or negative. I want to see a spark in the eye of the guy I’m talking to (...). I try to craft that in a stimulating way. I don’t only describe the job; I also try to make it sound exciting”.

The PM deals with each team member through a formal mandate and through an inspirational “mission”, often individualized. All through the project, he/she adjusts the mandates in accordance with the progress the employee makes or the difficulties he encounters.

- *The project manager balances constraints and freedom.* Interviewed PMs were looking for something they had difficulties to define. The PM in the video-game firm puts it this way:

“Sometimes the work flows naturally. The atmosphere is good and the guys look concentrated but not too serious. They joke but they don’t act too foolish. Even conflicts seem to be a natural part of the job, and they’re being taken care of without a fight or frustration. Then, we are much more productive than usual. I don’t know what it is, but I like that”.

This comment and many more observations in the field were referring to the state of “flow” [64,65], where the individual masters the rules and constraints of the context and feel fully in touch with and in control of the situation. He/she becomes part of the situation; literally surfing on the challenges. This occurs when the balance between constraints and freedom is finely set. When the individual thinks that the challenge could be tackled with and is meaningful, then he/she can progress and learn through his/her work, fully engaged. The PMs we observed did not seem formally aware of what the flow is; yet they were very conscious of what it takes to make it happen. The PM in the multimedia firm comments:

“I try to fine-tune the level of challenge, but it’s not easy: if I let them too loose, nothing happens and they waste their time. But I know I can’t always pressure them: I have to let them breathe. I’m always playing with the limits (...). I’m trying to find a balance...”

The creative director in the advertising agency seems to have an insight on how to assess this state of flow: fun! He explains how he monitors one creative duet:

“I know that everything is ok when I hear them laugh. They challenge each others and they shoot crazy ideas in the process. If one makes the other laugh, the other would react with a crazier idea, and so on and so forth. They have fun while building on each others ideas. Fun is an important part of the process”.

- *The project manager believes in fun.* In those cases, fun is not a marginal consequence of the process; it is at the heart. That is what “flow” is all about: enjoying the creative exploitation of the environment and the possibilities to express oneself through the mastery of the rules and constraints of the project. This is strictly similar to the enjoyment the player experiences while playing games: determined by the rules, but yet using them to achieve the goal [60]. The creative director in the advertising agency concludes: *“I do believe in fun. That’s really powerful (...). It’s all about enjoying what you’re involved in. If you enjoy it, you’re going to be good at it”*. Having fun at work still seems almost “taboo” in most business environments; yet challenging, co-opetitive and fun-inducing contexts may well be among the main sources of mobilisation of the new creative generation at work [67,69–74].

5. Concluding remarks

This study remains exploratory and needs further empirical validation/refutation and a stronger effort in theorization. However, it has the merit to account for the pluralistic and complex roles well-balanced creative project managers are playing in their field. We do not propose strong theoretical claims based on this fieldwork. Rather we would like to use this rich and detailed picture to emphasize three points to expose some reflections and insights for further research.

First point, we would like to stress the congruency of our observations with the main trends in research on creative leadership. Most of our observations could easily be reinterpreted, discussed and debated in the perspective of the theoretical research on leadership for creativity of the last twenty years. These descriptions are mostly consistent with the classical description of the manager's job, the project managers play interpersonal, informational and decisional roles [37]. From the point of view of the management of creativity, our project managers act in accordance with the now classical description of creative leadership [2]. All through the four sets of activities introduced here, the creative PMs were mostly providing the individuals and the team with meaning, knowledge-sharing spaces, and a balance of challenges and support. They would act as context builders more than plan-and-control managers [75]. Project managers trust the expertise of their employees and focus in defining a clear orientation for the project and a supportive context all along the project. Support is granted through imposed and negotiated rules, communication and animation, leaving a lot of freedom for experimentation, trials and errors. Motivation is fostered through the implementation of a creative climate [76,77] based on clarity of objectives, careful job assignments and alignment of individuals' interests with sub-mandates, a constant reassertion of challenges, permanent recognition of achievement, reinforcement through sense-making, and a sense of collective fun. As our accounts are not completely new in this perspective, they contribute in two ways to the understanding of the management of creative teams in projects. First, in grounding our descriptions into the deeds and words of managers, those descriptions bring some flesh to more and more abstract theoretical considerations. Second, those observations allow understanding into more details how project managers concretely handle individual and collective creativity in projects.

Our second insight proposes to reconsider the activities of project managers involved in creative endeavours through the framework that emerged from the fieldwork. As a "sense-maker", the main concern of creative project managers seem to be to establish a "platform of understanding", fuelled by "shared meaning". The project manager would spend time and efforts to establish a common ground for collective action. As a "web-weaver", he/she would reinforce these sense-making activities through intensive work in developing a communication infrastructure and social context that favour learning and knowledge

sharing. In this regards, this framework is consistent with some previous experimental work on creative leadership and team development which raises similar issues about the orientation of project managers as creative leaders [78]. The PM's second main concern seems to be to keep the level of individual engagement and motivation as high and aligned as possible. As a "game-master", he/she would also try to maintain and develop the common ground as a *playground*, where each individual would participate, get involved and feel challenged according to his/her own talents. In doing so, he/she handles another issue emphasized by Ekvall and Arvonen [79], constant change. Change is addressed through micro-challenges at the individual level and through reciprocal "co-opetitive" challenges at the inter-individual level, which foster intrinsic motivation. It can be hypothesized here that this is one important key issue to answer the main concern of creative project managers: performing. As "game-masters" and "flow-balancers", the creative project managers we observed would put a very strong emphasis on the quality of the experience for any team members and on the never-ending quest for "flow". Flow and fun seem to be more and more acknowledged as a powerful lever for creativity in "new wave" organizations and projects [43–47]. Further research is needed to develop a better understanding of the emergence of flow/fun through concrete managerial practice. One interesting perspective emerging from the field is to consider the creative project as a – very serious – game. According to our observations, that is what creative project managers actually do, framing and animating the team with clear goals and visions, crafting empowering rules, and focusing on developing a subtle balance between constraints and freedom. This approach is consistent with the structural definition of what a game is: "the invention of a freedom in/by a set of rules" [60]. According to one informant, this balance is the key to creative performance: "We provide the employees with a work environment where they can experiment, learn, share tricks, within clear boundaries. It's all about those boundaries, the space they create and the resources and support we bring in. If everything is there, they will play the game and give their best, because they would experience deep fun. We let them play, but fine-tuning the rules is a lot of work!" Congruent with the well-known work of Csikszentmihalyi, these insights still ask for empirical research to account for the concrete management of work as play and its efficiency [64,65].

In line with recent works on middle-management [80,81], our third and final comment takes the shape of a praise of creative project managers. Simple practice as the public rewarding of positive realisation and the one-and-one evaluation of errors shows the embedded tacit wisdom of project managers. As the main interface, they play a determining role in integrating the group, the individual and the organizational context [82]. The time and efforts they would spend to clarify the meaning of individual and collective action and to craft a cohesive image of the project should draw researchers' attention back on the

reflexivity in action in such creative projects. If we expect to address further the need for a multilevel understanding of the management of creative teams and projects, theoretical integration will ask for more research at the concrete end of the continuum: direct observations and qualitative accounts of project managers' actual actions, intuitive decision-making and rationale.

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